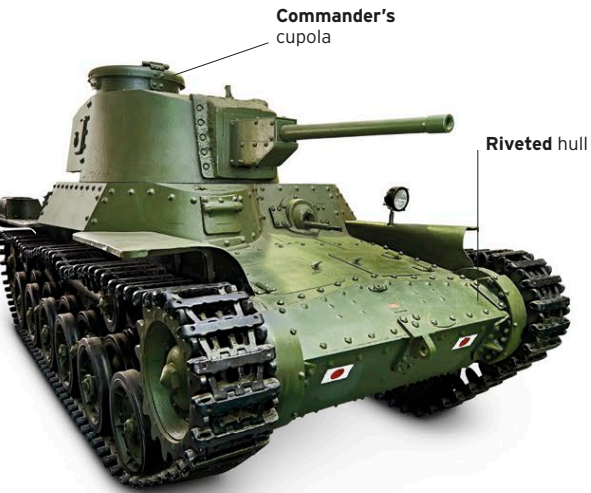


Axis Tanks: 1941-45

The North African Campaign, which began in 1940, was followed in 1941 by the German invasion of the Soviet Union and the Japanese attack on Pearl Harbor. As fighting intensified, tank technology evolved—so much so that by the end of the war tanks had the kind of firepower, protection, and reliability that were undreamed-of in 1939. However, technology wasn't everything. The Germans built ever more formidable vehicles, but these were plagued by mechanical failure and inexperienced crews. Tanks produced by Italy and Japan (the other Axis powers), being less advanced, were increasingly outclassed against the Allied armies.



▽ **Type 95 Ha-Go**

Date	1936	Country	Japan
Weight	8.3 tons (7.5 tonnes)		
Engine	Mitsubishi 6-cylinder diesel, 110 hp		
Main armament	37 mm Type 98 gun		

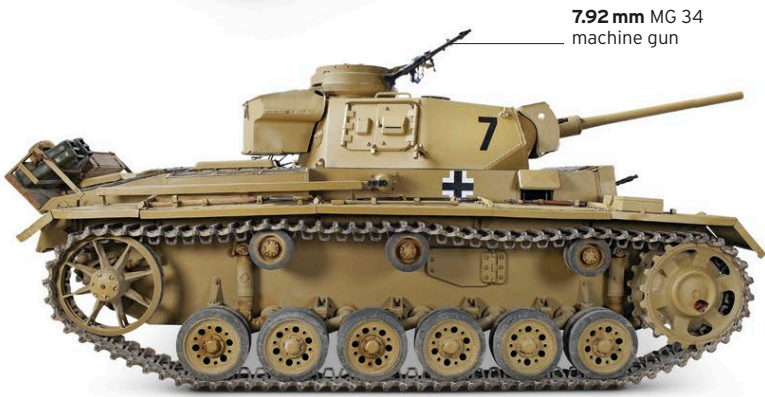
The Type 95 was popular with its crews and remained in front-line Japanese service throughout World War II. It was successful against the Chinese in the late 1930s, and in the early Japanese victories in 1942, but as Allied tanks began to enter combat it was soon outmatched. Its engine was powerful for its size, and its light weight made it useful on difficult terrain.



◁ **Type 97 Chi-Ha**

Date	1937	Country	Japan
Weight	16.8 tons (15.2 tonnes)		
Engine	Mitsubishi Type 97 diesel, 170 hp		
Main armament	47 mm Type 1 gun		

The Type 97 medium tank had a similar design to the Ha-Go, and featured a 57 mm gun optimized for infantry support. However, shortcomings in its firepower were exposed in the Battle of Khalkin Gol in 1939. The Japanese responded with the improved Shinhoto Chi-Ha, which had a 47 mm antitank gun.



△ **Panzer III Ausf L**

Date	1937	Country	Germany
Weight	25.4 tons (23.1 tonnes)		
Engine	Maybach HL120TRM gasoline, 300 hp		
Main armament	5 cm KwK 39 L/60 gun		

The Panzer III's armor and gun were both upgraded after combat experience in France. This version, the Ausf L, had 50 mm armor and a 5 cm gun. It fought in the Soviet Union and North Africa, but was replaced by the Panzer IV from 1942. The final Panzer III variant mounted the same 7.5 cm howitzer as the first Panzer IVs.

▷ **Panzer IV Ausf H**

Date	1937	Country	Germany
Weight	28 tons (25.4 tonnes)		
Engine	Maybach 120TRM petrol, 300 hp		
Main armament	7.5 cm KwK 40 L/48 gun		

First produced in 1937, the Panzer IV was upgraded in 1942. The addition of the long 7.5 cm gun promoted it from its original role as a support tank to that of the German Army's primary antitank vehicle. Its armor protection was also improved, including large add-on skirts and turret armor. Roughly 8,500 were built, making it the most commonly used German tank of World War II.



▷ **M14/41**

Date	1940	Country	Italy
Weight	16 tons (14.5 tonnes)		
Engine	SPA 15T M41 diesel, 145 hp		
Main armament	47 mm M35 L/32 gun		

Italy learned lessons from sending tanks into the Spanish Civil War. New vehicles were designed, as a result of that experience, and first saw service in North Africa in 1940. The M14/41 was an upgraded version of the M13/40 that was optimized for desert conditions. It was well armed, but its armor was no match for the Allies' 2-pounder gun.

